

# Orchestrating Your Life with AI Agents

A systems approach, not a coding one

# Four ways to use AI for ongoing projects

A trip. A health question that lasts a year. A side project. The people you owe replies to.

## One question, one chat

New conversation, paste in the context, ask, get an answer.

Next time: explain it again.

## Read AI search summaries

Read the AI summary at the top of search results.

60% of U.S. adults read these summaries; 49% use chatbots.

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Overlapping groups — Pew, June 2026

## Let the app remember

Use the app's memory or project features to keep context.

The context is somewhere. In their app.

## Paste or attach context

41% of surveyed U.S. AI users have uploaded a file, image, or document for analysis.

That measures ever-use, not use every session.

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Epoch AI/Ipsos, 2026

My test for any approach, three months later: **where does this stand, what did I decide, and why?**

# Where it breaks, once a project outlives a conversation

The same four failures, in every tool I tried

**You re-explain.** Every session starts from the model's memory of you, not the project's record.

**You can't update, only append.** Things change; the folder just gets one more conversation.

**The record isn't yours.** It's in a vendor's app, in a vendor's format, on a vendor's timeline.

**The "why" is gone.** You can find that you kept the hotel and changed the bus. Not why.

And whatever fixes this can't become a job. Keeping the system running has to stay small.

# How I got here

Three steps, each ended by something that broke

## STEP 1

### Projects in the chat apps

A folder of related conversations, some memory across them.

Useful. A place to hold chats.

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Broke: I couldn't update the project as things evolved. I just kept adding conversations.

## STEP 2

### A skill per area of life

Put the context in a skill file. Call it whenever the topic comes up. Let the assistant update it.

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Broke: a skill is a standard operating procedure. It was never built to hold a record over months.

## STEP 3 — NOW

### The record in a folder; the skill, a pointer

One folder of plain files per project: purpose, status, decisions with reasons, next actions, sources, rules for the assistant.

The skill shrinks to a few lines: go here, read these first.

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What it costs: a few minutes a session.

Each step was fine until the project outlived it.

# Orchestrating your life: the view from 30,000 feet

Not one assistant. One person, one folder of workspaces, any agentic harness, any device.

ONE FOLDER ON YOUR MACHINE · SYNCED TO A PRIVATE BACKUP

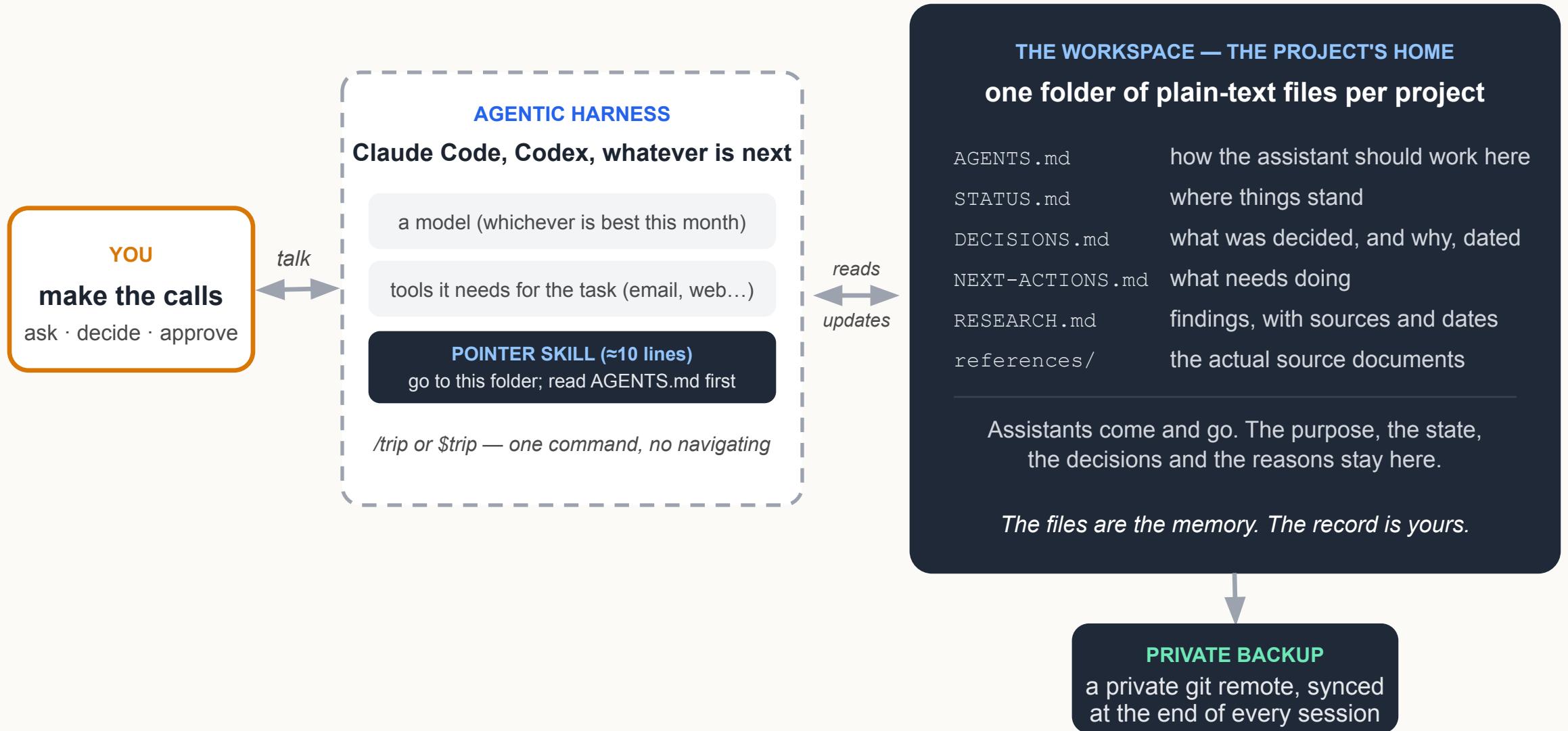


**Every box is the same thing:** a folder of plain files with a purpose, a status, decisions with reasons, and next actions. Same rules, same shape, so any harness knows its way around any of them.

**Getting in takes one command,** from any harness, on any device: `/trip` at the desk, the same thing from the phone in the car. Assistants and models get swapped; the folders stay.

# Who does the work, where the record lives, what can be replaced

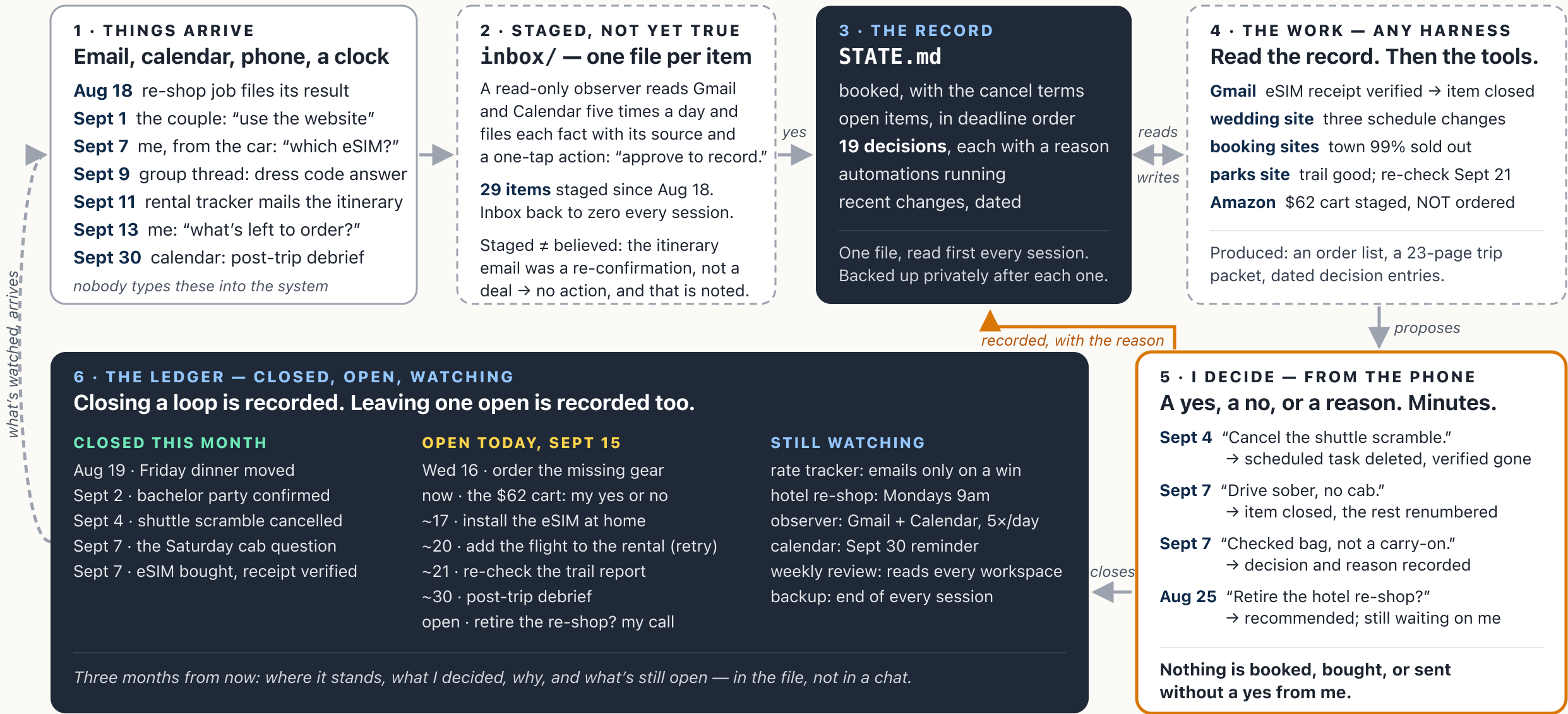
■ owned — keep for years    □ replaceable — pick per task, per year    □ you — the only constant



# One real workspace, one month: the loop

The trip workspace, Aug 18 – Sept 30. Every arrow below actually happened. Names and numbers stripped.

redacted copy of a live record · shown live next



**What it costs:** a few minutes a day. **What broke anyway:** a search missed an email that had arrived; a scheduled job died and couldn't report its own death.

**Try it: one workspace for one real project**



`https://github.com/rdmayo21/agentic-workspaces`

Templates + pointer-skill setup for Claude Code, Codex, Gemini CLI. MIT.

**Use it for a month. Then tell me what I'm missing.**